

BookLore 3.0

Familiarization Guide

A friendly, complete walkthrough of everything BookLore can do — written for users of all experience levels.

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Audience: New and non-technical users

This guide should be updated whenever features are added, changed, or removed.

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1. What Is BookLore?

BookLore is a **self-hosted digital library** — a personal application you run on your own computer or server to organize, read, and manage your book and comic collection. Think of it as your own private digital bookshelf accessible from any web browser on any device.

Supported Formats

Format	Description
PDF	Standard document files (books, manuals, magazines)
EPUB	Common e-book format used by most e-readers
CBZ / CBR	Comic book archives (zipped or RAR-compressed image collections)
Audiobooks	Audio files organized in folders (MP3, M4A, etc.)
Physical Books	Catalog entries for physical books you own (no digital file required)

What You Can Do

- Store and organize thousands of books across multiple libraries
- Read books, comics, and listen to audiobooks directly in your browser
- Track your reading progress across devices
- Highlight text, add bookmarks, and write notes
- Search and filter your entire collection
- Fetch book information (metadata) from the internet automatically
- Share your catalog with e-readers via OPDS feeds
- Manage multiple users with different access levels
- Use AI to detect comic panels for panel-by-panel reading

2. Getting Started — First-Time Setup

When you open BookLore for the very first time, you will see the **Setup Wizard**.

What You Do

1. **Create your admin account** — Choose a username and strong password. This is the main administrator account.
2. **Set up your first library** — Point BookLore to the folder on disk where your books are stored (for example, `/books`).

3. **Configure authentication** — Choose how users will log in (local password, OIDC, or forward auth).

What You Can't Do

- You cannot skip creating the admin account — it is required.
- You cannot change the admin username later through the normal interface.
- You cannot undo the first-time setup once completed — but you can change all settings afterward.

Be Careful: Choose a strong password. Anyone who knows this password has full control over BookLore. If you lose the admin password and have no other login method configured, recovery requires direct database access.

3. The Dashboard — Your Home Screen

The Dashboard is the first screen you see after logging in. It provides a quick overview of your library.

What You Can Do

- See library statistics at a glance (total books, reading status, etc.)
- Access recently added books
- Jump to any section using the sidebar navigation

What You Can't Do

- Customize which statistics appear on the dashboard (the layout is fixed)

4. Navigating the Interface

BookLore uses a **sidebar + main content** layout.

Left Sidebar

Item	What It Does
Dashboard	Returns to the home screen
All Books	Shows every book across all your libraries
Physical Books	Shows your physical placeholders grouped by library, like a shelf overview for books you own off-screen
Libraries	Expandable list — click a library to see only its books
Shelves	Your custom collections
Not Shelfed	Books not assigned to any shelf
Series	Browse books grouped by series
Authors	Browse books by author
Magic Shelves	Your smart filtered collections
Settings (bottom)	Application configuration
Language (bottom)	Switch the interface language

What You Can Do

- **Resize sidebars** — Drag the edge of either sidebar to make it wider or narrower
- **Reorder sidebar items** — Click, hold, and drag sidebar entries to rearrange them
- **Collapse sections** — Click section headers to expand or collapse groups
- **Hide or show sidebar headings per user** — Heading visibility is now saved with your account, so the same layout follows you across sessions
- **Choose which HOME shortcuts appear** — Use the sidebar show/hide controls to decide whether entries like Dashboard, All Books, Physical Books, Series, Authors, and Notebook appear under HOME for your account
- **Keep Media Type labels and ordering per user** — Custom media types, recent choices, and the Media Type sidebar order now follow your account instead of staying in one browser only
- **Open the folder panel while browsing books** — Use the folder button in **All Books** or a library view to browse by real library directories

Good to Know: Switching between sidebar views does *not* reload your book grid from scratch — BookLore remembers what was on screen, so navigation is fast.

5. Libraries — Organizing Your Collection

A **Library** is a connection between BookLore and a folder on your computer or server where book files are stored.

What You Can Do

- **Create multiple libraries** — For example, one for “Fiction,” one for “Comics,” one for “Audiobooks”
- **Scan libraries** — Tell BookLore to look for new files in a library folder
- **Rescan libraries** — Force BookLore to re-examine all files in a library
- **See preparation feedback for large imports** — When creating a library with many files, the dialog now shows an in-between working state before the full progress overlay appears
- **Check library health** — Verify the folder is accessible and working
- **Delete libraries** — Remove a library from BookLore (optionally deleting its files too)
- **Restrict library access** — Control which users can see which libraries

What You Can't Do

- Assign the same folder to two different libraries (each folder should belong to one library)
- Manage files on remote cloud services directly — BookLore reads from local or network-mounted folders

Be Careful:

- **Deleting a library can optionally delete the actual files from disk.** If you only want to remove BookLore's catalog entry, make sure you uncheck “delete files from disk.”
- **Moving or renaming book files outside of BookLore** will cause them to appear missing. Always let BookLore manage file movements.
- **If your book folder is on a network drive**, set `DISK_TYPE=NETWORK` in your environment configuration for better compatibility. Automatic metadata writes stay disabled there, but you can still run manual sidecar backups when you want a portable metadata snapshot.

6. Books — Adding, Browsing, and Managing

Browsing Books

- **All Books** — View every book in your collection, displayed as a grid of cover images
- **Untitled cards fall back to the filename** — If a book has no stored metadata title yet, BookLore shows the asset filename on the card so the item remains identifiable

- **Library switching can feel faster after the first hover** — When you pause on a library in the sidebar, BookLore quietly warms a small set of that library's thumbnails so the next switch shows fewer blank covers while images stream in
- **Click any book cover** to open its detail page with full information
- **Close book details cleanly** — The back arrow in Book Details returns you to the page you opened from instead of walking backward through every detail view
- **Right-click a book cover** (or long-press on mobile) for quick actions

Directory Explorer

BookLore includes a **folder explorer panel** for book browsing. It lets you filter the current view by the actual folders inside your libraries instead of relying only on shelves or metadata filters.

Action	What It Does
Open the folder panel	Click the folder button while viewing All Books or a specific library
Expand a folder branch	Click the + or – toggle next to a top-level folder
Select a top-level folder	Click the folder row itself to show only books stored directly in that root folder, with folders and files defaulting to filename order for easier shelf-style browsing
Select a subfolder	Click a nested folder to show books inside that folder and its child folders, again defaulting the visible folders and assets to filename order until you pick a different sort
Clear a folder filter	Click the selected folder again, or use the normal filter clear action
Browse across libraries	In All Books , the panel shows each library root so you can filter across multiple libraries from one screen

What You Can Do

Action	How
View book details	Click the book cover
Read a book	Click “Read” on the detail page or double-click the cover
Add to a shelf	Right-click → Add to Shelf, or use the book detail page
Remove from shelf	Right-click → Remove from Shelf
Change reading status	Set to: Not Started, Reading, Completed, or Abandoned
Rate a book	Give it 1–5 stars on the detail page
Edit metadata	Update title, author, description, cover, etc.
Delete a book	Right-click → Delete (with optional disk deletion)
Delete multiple books	Select books (checkbox mode) then delete in bulk
Add a physical book	Create a catalog entry for a book you own physically in a chosen library directory, while keeping it available for metadata, covers, shelves, and filters
Assign file type	Choose how to open a file (e.g., read a PDF as an e-book instead)

Good to Know: Physical books stay visible as normal library assets after you create them. You can find them from **Physical Books** under HOME, from library and shelf views, and from the **Media Type** → **Physical** filter. BookLore also blocks creating a second matching physical placeholder in the same library directory when it already finds the same physical ISBN or the same title/author placeholder there. Physical placeholders now also write a small directory sidecar in their chosen library folder, so a later rebuild or refresh can recreate them from disk-backed metadata instead of losing them.

Backup Friendly: The **Sidecar** tools for a physical placeholder now target its library directory instead of requiring a digital book file. This gives you a portable metadata backup for physical entries and lets library-wide sidecar exports include physical books too.

What You Can't Do

- Directly edit the book file contents (BookLore is a reader and organizer, not an editor)
- Upload books from this screen (use BookDrop for that — see Section 7)

- Move or rename folders from the directory panel (it is a browser/filtering tool, not a file manager)

Be Careful:

- **Deleting a book with “delete from disk” enabled is permanent.** The file is gone. There is no recycle bin.
- **Bulk deleting books** is powerful — double-check your selection before confirming.
- **If you delete the only readable format from a normal digital book**, BookLore now removes that empty catalog shell instead of leaving behind a metadata-only entry. If you want a deliberate metadata-only placeholder, create a **Physical Book** instead.

7. BookDrop — Importing New Books

BookDrop is a **watch folder** — a special folder where you drop new book files, and BookLore will detect and import them.

How It Works

1. **Place files** in the BookDrop folder (usually mapped to `./bookdrop` in Docker)
2. **BookLore detects** the new files automatically (or you can click “Rescan”)
3. **Go to the BookDrop page** in BookLore to see pending files
4. **Review and edit** — Adjust metadata, assign to a library, set the destination path
5. **Finalize** — Click to import the files into your library

What You Can Do

Action	Description
Rescan	Manually trigger a scan of the BookDrop folder
Preview files	See file details before importing
Edit metadata	Change title, author, cover, etc. before import
Bulk edit	Update metadata for multiple files at once
Pattern extraction	Automatically parse filenames to extract title, author, series, etc.
Choose destination	Pick which library and folder path to import into
Discard files	Skip files you don't want to import
Finalize import	Move files from BookDrop into your library

What You Can't Do

- Import files directly from a URL or the internet — you must first download them to the BookDrop folder
- Import unsupported file formats (stick to PDF, EPUB, CBZ, CBR, and audio formats)

Be Careful:

- **Files are moved, not copied**, during import. After finalization, the original file in BookDrop is removed.
- **Pattern extraction is only as good as your filename.** If filenames are messy, you may need to edit metadata manually.
- **Don't put files into BookDrop while a scan is actively running.** Wait for the scan to complete first, then add files and rescan.

8. Shelves — Custom Collections

Shelves are like playlists for your books. You can create as many as you want and assign any book to one or more shelves.

What You Can Do

Action	Description
Create a shelf	Give it a name and optionally an icon
Add books	Assign books to a shelf from the book detail page or right-click menu
Remove books	Take books off a shelf without deleting them
Rename a shelf	Change its name anytime
Delete a shelf	Remove the shelf (books are not deleted)
Browse a shelf	Click a shelf in the sidebar to see only its books
Make a shelf public	Admins can make shelves visible to all users
Kobo device shelf	Special shelf type that syncs to connected Kobo e-readers

Tip: Click **Not Shelfed** in the sidebar to see every book not assigned to any shelf — useful for organizing new additions.

What You Can't Do

- Nest shelves inside other shelves (shelves are flat, not hierarchical)

Good to Know: Deleting a shelf does *NOT* delete its books. The books remain in your library — only the shelf grouping is removed.

9. Magic Shelves — Smart Filtered Collections

Magic Shelves are **automatic collections** that populate themselves based on rules you define. They update automatically as your library changes.

Examples

- “Books I Haven’t Read Yet” (filter: reading status = Not Started)
- “5-Star Books” (filter: rating = 5)
- “All Comics” (filter: media type = Comic)
- “Books by Stephen King” (filter: author = Stephen King)
- “Added This Month” (filter: date added = last 30 days)

What You Can Do

- Create magic shelves with custom filter rules
- Combine multiple filters (e.g., “Unread comics rated 4+ stars”)
- Edit filter rules anytime — the shelf updates automatically
- Make them public (admin only) — share with all users
- Delete magic shelves when no longer needed

What You Can't Do

- Manually add or remove specific books from a magic shelf — membership is determined entirely by the filter rules

Be Careful: A magic shelf with very broad rules may include thousands of books, which can slow down loading.

10. Reading Books

BookLore includes built-in readers for every supported format. Each reader is tailored to its format.

a) PDF Reader

Opens PDF files (books, manuals, documents) in a dedicated viewer.

Feature	Description
Page navigation	Go to any page, use forward/back arrows, or type a page number
Table of contents	Jump to chapters using the built-in outline (if the PDF has one)
Page thumbnails	See small previews of all pages for quick navigation
Zoom	Zoom in and out for easier reading
Bookmarks	Save your place with labeled bookmarks
Highlights	Select text and highlight it in different colors
Annotations	Add notes to highlighted sections
Reading progress	Automatically saved — pick up where you left off

What You Can't Do: Edit PDF text, fill in forms, or print directly from BookLore (use your browser's print function).

Be Careful: Very large PDFs (hundreds of megabytes) may load slowly. Some complex PDFs with unusual formatting may not render perfectly.

b) E-Book (EPUB) Reader

Opens EPUB e-book files with a clean, comfortable reading experience.

Feature	Description
Chapter navigation	Use the table of contents to jump between chapters
Adjust font size	Make text larger or smaller for comfortable reading
Adjust line spacing	Increase or decrease space between lines
Bookmarks	Save your place
Highlights	Select text and highlight in colors
Annotations	Write notes attached to highlighted text
Reading progress	Automatically tracked
Custom fonts	Upload and use your preferred fonts (see Settings)

What You Can't Do: Change the book's text or view DRM-protected (copy-protected) files.

Be Careful: BookLore only supports DRM-free e-books. DRM-locked files will not open.

c) Comic (CBX) Reader

Opens CBZ and CBR comic book files with page and panel navigation.

Feature	Description
Page navigation	Flip through comic pages
Page list	Jump to any page by number
Webtoon mode	Enable continuous vertical scrolling for web comics
AI panel detection	Navigate panel-by-panel within each page (requires AI feature)
Bookmarks	Mark favorite pages
Reading progress	Automatically tracked

What You Can't Do: Annotate or highlight on comic pages (image-based format), or edit/reorder pages.

Be Careful: CBR files (RAR format) may extract more slowly than CBZ files (ZIP format). Very high-resolution scans can use significant memory.

d) Audiobook Player

Plays audiobooks — collections of audio files organized in a folder.

Feature	Description
Track listing	See all tracks/chapters in the audiobook
Play / Pause	Standard audio controls
Seek / Scrub	Jump forward or backward within a track
Chapter navigation	Skip between tracks/chapters
Duration display	See total and remaining time
Progress tracking	Automatically saves your listening position

What You Can't Do: Adjust playback speed natively (use browser extensions if needed).

Be Careful: Audiobooks must be organized as folders containing audio files. Make sure files are in common formats (MP3, M4A, OGG, etc.).

11. Bookmarks, Annotations, and the Notebook

Bookmarks

Simple position markers with an optional label. Use them to mark pages you want to return to.

- **Create:** While reading, click the bookmark icon at your current position
- **Label:** Give bookmarks descriptive names (e.g., “Important chapter”)
- **Color coding:** Assign colors to categorize bookmarks
- **Navigate:** Click any bookmark to jump back to that spot
- **Delete:** Remove bookmarks when no longer needed

Annotations (Highlights and Notes)

Available in PDF and EPUB readers.

- **Highlight:** Select text → choose a highlight color
- **Underline / Strikethrough:** Additional marking styles
- **Add notes:** Attach written notes to any highlight
- **Edit:** Change colors, styles, or note text anytime
- **Delete:** Remove individual annotations

The Notebook

A centralized view of **all your annotations across every book**.

- See all highlights and notes in one place
- Filter by book, type, or date
- Search through your annotations
- Export all annotations for backup
- Quickly jump to the source book and location

Good to Know: Annotations are created while reading — you cannot create them from the Notebook view.

12. Reading Progress and Statistics

Reading Progress

- **Automatic saving** — Your position is saved every time you read
- **Resume reading** — Open a book and you’re taken right back to where you left off

- **Reading status** — Set to: Not Started, Reading, Completed, or Abandoned
- **Sync across devices** — Read on your phone then your computer; progress stays in sync

Reading Statistics Page

Statistic	What It Shows
Books completed	Total count of finished books
Currently reading	Books you're in the middle of
Reading streaks	Consecutive days with reading activity
Time spent	Total time spent reading
Monthly / Yearly breakdown	Reading activity over time
Favorite authors	Most-read authors based on your habits

Library Statistics Page

A separate page showing collection-level statistics: total books by format, genre, author, series; books by reading status; collection growth over time; and most recent additions. When AI panel data exists, the page also shows AI-scanned comic totals and stored AI panel-data size for the selected library.

13. Series and Authors

Series

Books can be grouped into series (e.g., “Harry Potter,” “The Walking Dead”).

- **Browse by series** — Click “Series” in the sidebar
- **View all books in a series** — Click a series name to see its books in order
- Series are auto-detected from metadata

What You Can’t Do: Manually create a series from scratch (series come from book metadata) or reorder books within a series.

Authors

- **Browse all authors** — Alphabetical listing with book counts
- **View author details** — Biography, photo, and all their books
- **Edit author information** — Update name, bio, description, photo
- **Upload author photos** — Add images for authors who don’t have one

Tip: Use consistent author names in book metadata to avoid duplicate author entries (e.g., always “J.K. Rowling,” not sometimes “Rowling, J.K.”).

14. Metadata — Book Information

Metadata is all the information about a book: title, author, description, cover image, publication date, genre, ISBN, and more.

Fetching Metadata from the Internet

Action	Description
Fetch metadata	Search online providers by title, author, or ISBN
Preview results	See what information was found before applying
Apply selectively	Choose which fields to update
Replace all	Overwrite all metadata with fetched information
Merge	Keep your edits and fill in only the missing fields
Fetch covers	Download book cover images
Fetch author info	Download author biographies and photos

Editing Metadata Manually

- Edit title, author, description, and all other fields by hand
- Upload a custom cover image
- Add or change genres, categories, and moods
- Set or update ISBN, publication date, and language
- Delete all editable metadata directly beside the fetch actions when you want to clear a book and immediately refetch it
- Delete all editable metadata for a single book from the metadata editor when you want to start over cleanly
- Create custom media types (Magazines, Textbooks, etc.)

Be Careful:

- **“Replace All” overwrites everything**, including any manual edits you’ve made. Use “Merge” if you want to keep your changes.
- **Fetches cover images may not match your edition.** Review the cover before applying.
- **ISBN lookup is the most reliable** way to get accurate metadata. Use it when available.

- You cannot undo a metadata overwrite once applied.

15. Metadata Manager — Bulk Editing

The Metadata Manager lets you edit metadata for many books at once.

What You Can Do

- Select multiple books for batch metadata operations
- Apply the same genre, category, or mood to many books at once
- Bulk-update reading status or media type
- Bulk-fetch metadata for selected books, with better recovery when a provider's first match fails but later candidates still contain usable metadata
- Delete all metadata for selected books from the bulk selection action bar

Be Careful: Bulk edits are immediate and cannot be reversed. Double-check your selection and changes before applying. Start with small batches to verify results. Bulk metadata deletion clears the selected books' metadata in one step.

Good to Know: If one metadata source fails to return a usable first match during a bulk custom scan, BookLore now falls back more gracefully instead of abandoning that whole book as aggressively. For providers that temporarily throttle large jobs, BookLore now retries the throttled request itself after the cooldown window, keeps the metadata task visible as still running, shows a provider-wait message with both the reset ETA and the current time left, lets metadata editors cancel those metadata jobs directly from the progress widget even without broader task-manager access, interrupts long ComicVine cooldown waits promptly when you cancel the job, and uses a lighter top-match lookup path for ComicVine batch scans so large runs are less likely to exhaust the hourly request budget mid-batch.

16. Search and Filtering

Global Search

Type in the search bar to find books across your entire collection by title, author name, description, or ISBN.

Filters

Filter	Options
Library	Show books from a specific library only
Directory / Folder	Show books from a selected top-level folder or subfolder in the directory explorer
Shelf	Show books on a specific shelf
Reading status	Not Started, Reading, Completed, Abandoned
Media type	E-book, PDF, Comic, Audiobook, Physical, Custom types
Author	Filter by specific author
Series	Filter by series
Genre / Category	Filter by genre or category tag
Rating	Filter by your personal star rating
Language	Filter by book language

What You Can Do

- Combine multiple filters (e.g., “Unread comics in my Comics library”)
- Filter by real storage folders from the directory explorer while keeping your other filters active
- Use **Media Type** → **Physical** from the sidebar to see only physical placeholders, or mix it with other filters like library, shelf, and reading status
- Hover the filter-mode buttons to see what each mode does: **AND** requires every selected filter to match, **OR** accepts any selected match, **NOT** hides matches, and **1** keeps only one active selection at a time
- Keep your filter sidebar visibility, filter sort mode, and expanded filter groups with your user account instead of one browser profile
- Clear all filters with one click

Good to Know: In **AND** mode, the tag and sidebar option lists now narrow themselves to combinations that can actually exist together. After you choose one tag, BookLore only offers additional tags that still leave at least one matching book in the current result set.

Mode Changes Reset Sidebar Selections: Switching between **AND**, **OR**, **NOT**, and **1** now clears the current sidebar filter selections first. This prevents an old selection set from being silently reinterpreted under a different mode.

What Changed: After you already have sidebar selections active, switching to a different filter mode now updates the highlighted mode button immediately on the first click instead of waiting for a second click to make the new mode look selected.

Duplicate Review

BookLore's duplicate finder is now designed as a **scoped review tool**. Open it from a library menu, then choose whether to scan your **current filtered view**, the **current library**, or **all libraries**.

Sidecar Backup Coverage: Manual per-library sidecar backup now follows each book's real readable file even when a book also has non-book attachments, so EPUB, PDF, CBR, and CBZ titles are backed up alongside physical placeholders instead of only the physical entries appearing.

Good to Know: The duplicate review screen is intentionally non-destructive. It shows likely duplicate groups, highlights a suggested book to keep, lets you inspect another candidate side-by-side, and can open book details or launch a reader for digital files without deleting or merging anything.

Why This Matters: Using the current filtered view lets you investigate duplicates only inside the slice you are already looking at, such as a single shelf, a search result, a folder, or a filtered library window, without scanning the rest of the collection.

Manual Resolution Plans: After reviewing a duplicate group, you can now mark your preferred book to keep, queue the group into a manual resolution list, and then copy or download that plan for follow-up. This gives you a safe handoff document without changing any book records.

Saved to Your Account: Your queued duplicate-resolution plan now follows your BookLore user account. If you close the dialog and come back later, BookLore can restore the saved scan scope and reapply the queued keep choices to matching duplicate groups after the next scan.

Saved Snapshot: Before you rescan, BookLore now shows the queued duplicate groups already stored on your account, including the preferred keep, the match reason, and the other candidates that were part of that saved plan.

Custom Matching Starts Empty: If you choose the **Custom** matching preset, BookLore now clears all matching signals first so you can build your own scan from a blank starting point instead of inheriting the previous preset.

What You Can't Do

- Search inside book contents (search only covers metadata)
- Save filter combinations as presets (use Magic Shelves instead)

17. AI Comic Panel Detection

An **optional** feature that uses artificial intelligence to detect individual panels on comic book pages, enabling panel-by-panel reading.

How to Use

1. Enable AI in **Settings** → **AI Panel Detection**
2. Wait for status to show "READY"
3. Open a comic in the reader
4. Click the AI button to scan the current book
5. Or use bulk scan from AI settings to process all comics at once

What You Can Do

- Scan individual comics or bulk scan entire libraries
- Delete panel data for specific comics
- View statistics on scanned comics, including saved scan counts and stored AI panel-data size
- Reload the AI model if it stops responding

What You Can't Do

- Use panel detection on non-comic formats
- Guarantee 100% accurate panel detection — AI may occasionally miss or misidentify panels

Be Careful: AI processing uses significant CPU resources. Bulk scanning large collections may slow down your server. The AI container is optional — omit `COMPOSE_PROFILES=ai` from your environment to skip it entirely.

18. OPDS Feeds — E-Reader Integration

OPDS (Open Publication Distribution System) lets e-readers browse and download books directly from your BookLore library.

How to Set Up

1. Go to **Settings** → **OPDS**
2. Copy your personal OPDS feed URL
3. Enter the URL in your e-reader's OPDS catalog settings

What You Can Do

- Browse your library from any OPDS-compatible e-reader or app
- Download books directly to your e-reader
- Search your catalog from the e-reader's search function
- Access feeds by category: Libraries, Shelves, Magic Shelves, Series, Authors

What You Can't Do

- Stream audiobooks via OPDS (downloads only)
- Use OPDS to upload books to BookLore (download only)

Be Careful: Keep your OPDS token private. Anyone with the URL can access your library. If you change your token, all connected e-readers will need to be updated.

19. Kobo and KoReader Device Sync

BookLore can sync reading progress with **Kobo** and **KoReader** compatible devices.

What You Can Do

- Sync reading position between BookLore and your device
- Create a dedicated Kobo device shelf for content management
- Transfer books to your device and keep progress synchronized

What You Can't Do: Sync with Kindle devices directly (use OPDS or email-to-Kindle instead).

Be Careful: Device sync is experimental. Minor discrepancies in page positioning may occur between the web reader and physical device.

20. Email — Sending Books

How to Set Up

1. Go to **Settings** → **Email**

2. Configure your email provider (SMTP server, port, username, password)
3. Add recipient email addresses

What You Can Do

- Send individual books to configured email addresses
- Configure multiple recipients
- Use email templates for formatting

What You Can't Do

- Send books larger than your email provider's attachment limit (typically 25 MB)
- Send audiobooks via email (file sizes are too large)

Be Careful: Store your SMTP credentials securely. Large books may fail to send if they exceed your provider's size limit.

21. User Accounts and Permissions

User Roles

Role	Access Level
Admin	Full access to everything, including settings and user management
Regular User	Access to assigned libraries and personal features

Permissions (Configurable per User)

Permission	What It Allows
BookDrop Access	Upload and import books through BookDrop
Metadata Editing	Fetch and edit book metadata
Library Management	Create, modify, and delete libraries
Book Deletion	Delete books (optionally from disk)
Task Manager	View and run background tasks
View Audit Logs	Access the audit log

What Admins Can Do

- Create, edit, and delete user accounts
- Reset user passwords
- Assign permissions to each user
- Restrict users to specific libraries
- Make shelves and magic shelves public

What Regular Users Can Do

- Read books in their assigned libraries
- Create personal shelves and magic shelves
- Manage their own bookmarks, annotations, and reading progress
- Change their own password and profile

Be Careful:

- The **“Book Deletion” permission allows permanent file deletion from disk**. Only grant this to trusted users.
- **Library Management permission** allows creating and deleting libraries — grant carefully.

22. Authentication — Login Methods

BookLore supports three ways to log in:

Local Password

The default method — log in with your username and password. Simplest option for personal use. Passwords are stored securely (hashed). Sessions use JWT tokens that auto-refresh.

OIDC (OpenID Connect)

Use a third-party identity provider (like PocketID, Keycloak, or Authentik) for single sign-on.

1. Configure the OIDC provider (create a client for BookLore)
2. In BookLore Settings → Authentication, enter the Client ID, Issuer URI, and JWKS URL
3. Enable OIDC
4. Users can now log in with the “Login with [Provider]” button

Forward Auth (Reverse Proxy)

If you run BookLore behind a reverse proxy with an authentication layer (like Authelia), BookLore can trust the proxy's authentication headers.

Be Careful:

- **If using Forward Auth, NEVER expose BookLore directly to the internet.** Always route through your authenticated reverse proxy.
- **OIDC requires correct URL configuration.** Incorrect Issuer URI or JWKS URL will prevent login entirely.
- **Test new authentication settings before disabling local login,** or you may lock yourself out.

23. Application Settings

Access settings via the gear icon at the bottom of the sidebar.

Category	What You Can Configure
Reader Settings	Default font size, zoom, reading mode preferences
View Preferences	Book grid layout, cover preview panel, toolbar customization
User Management	Create/edit/delete users and their permissions
Email	SMTP server for sending books via email
File Naming Patterns	How imported files are named and organized
Metadata	Default metadata providers and API keys
Metadata Persistence	Write metadata into files, manage automatic sidecars, and run a manual per-library sidecar backup even when automatic sidecars are disabled
Library Metadata	Per-library metadata provider configuration
Authentication	OIDC and forward auth configuration
OPDS	E-reader feed configuration
Tasks	Background task scheduling (cron jobs)
Audit Logs	View user activity logs
AI Panel Detection	Enable/disable and manage comic panel AI
Global Preferences	Theme (light/dark), language, timezone, settings backup

Customizable Toolbar

- **Add or remove buttons** — Choose which actions appear in the toolbar
- **Reorder buttons** — Drag and drop to rearrange
- **Add separators** — Insert visual dividers between button groups

Be Careful:

- **Changing authentication settings can lock you out.** Test OIDC configuration before disabling local login.
- **Settings export/import includes sensitive data** (email credentials, API keys). Store exported files securely.

Good to Know:

- **Automatic sidecars and manual sidecar backups are separate.** You can keep automatic sidecar writing turned off and still run **Back Up Sidecars per Library** from Metadata Persistence when you want an on-demand metadata backup.
- **The backup action is available in both LOCAL and NETWORK disk modes.** Network mode still blocks automatic rewrite and file reorganization, but the manual sidecar backup action remains available as an explicit exception.
- **Running the backup again refreshes existing backup sidecars.** BookLore rewrites the selected library's sidecar files with the current database metadata instead of requiring you to delete old backups first.

24. Background Tasks

BookLore can run jobs in the background to maintain and update your library.

Task	What It Does
Library Scan	Detect newly added book files
Library Rescan	Full re-scan of all files in a library
Metadata Refresh	Re-fetch metadata from providers for existing books
Deleted Books Cleanup	Remove catalog entries for files that no longer exist on disk
Temp Metadata Cleanup	Clear old cached metadata from previous searches
BookDrop Scan	Check the BookDrop folder for new files
KEPUB Conversion	Convert book formats for e-reader compatibility

What You Can Do

- Run tasks manually — Start any task on demand
- Schedule tasks — Set up automatic timing
- Cancel running tasks
- View task history and results

Be Careful:

- **Library Rescan on a very large library** can take a long time and use significant resources.
- **Metadata Refresh** makes network calls — running too frequently may cause rate limiting from providers.

25. Backup and Restore

Protecting your BookLore data requires backing up **two things**:

1. Application Settings (Database)

Quick Export (Settings Only)

1. Go to **Settings** → **Global Preferences** → **Settings Transfer**
2. Click **Export**
3. Save the downloaded JSON file

This exports libraries, users, shelves, metadata settings, and preferences.

Full Database Backup (Recommended)

For complete protection (including all book metadata, reading progress, annotations, and shelf assignments), use a database dump:

```
docker exec mariadb mariadb-dump \  
  --single-transaction --quick --no-tablespaces \  
  -u root -p"YOUR_ROOT_PASSWORD" \  
  booklore > booklore_backup.sql
```

2. Book Files and Data

What to Back Up	Folder
Book files	<code>./books/</code>
Covers, thumbnails, and images	<code>./data/</code>
BookDrop inbox	<code>./bookdrop/</code>

Be Careful:

- **Settings export does NOT include reading progress, annotations, or book files.** For full protection, do a database dump AND file backup.
- **Store backups in a separate location** from your BookLore server.
- **Test your backups periodically.** A backup you've never tested is a backup you can't trust.

26. Audit Logs

What Is Logged

- User logins and logouts
- Book operations (create, update, delete)
- Shelf changes
- Metadata updates
- Settings changes
- User management actions
- BookDrop operations

What You Can Do

- View the full audit log (admin only)
- Filter by user, action type, or date
- Track who made changes and when

What You Can't Do: Delete individual log entries (logs are append-only).

27. Tips and Best Practices

For New Users

1. **Start small.** Set up one library, add a few books, and explore before importing your entire collection.
2. **Use BookDrop** for importing rather than manually placing files.
3. **Fetch metadata early.** After importing, fetch metadata to fill in titles, authors, covers, and descriptions.
4. **Create shelves** to organize your favorites.
5. **Set your reading status** so you can track what you've read.

For Security

1. Use strong passwords for all accounts, especially the admin account.
2. Never expose BookLore directly to the internet without a reverse proxy and authentication.
3. Keep your OPDS token private.
4. Review user permissions carefully — only grant deletion rights to trusted users.
5. Back up regularly — both the database and your book files.

For Performance

1. Use CBZ over CBR when possible — ZIP extraction is faster than RAR.
2. Keep image sizes reasonable — extremely high-resolution scans use more memory.
3. Schedule background tasks during off-hours.
4. Don't scan libraries too frequently — once-daily scans are usually sufficient.

For Organization

1. Be consistent with author names to avoid duplicates.
2. Use genres and categories — they make filtering and Magic Shelves more useful.
3. Rate your books — ratings enable great Magic Shelf filters.
4. Use the Notebook to review all your annotations in one place.

28. Glossary

Term	Definition
Library	A connection between BookLore and a folder on your server where book files are stored
Shelf	A user-created collection for grouping books (like a playlist)
Magic Shelf	An automatically populated collection based on filter rules
BookDrop	A watch folder where you place new files for BookLore to import
Metadata	Information about a book — title, author, description, cover, ISBN, etc.
OPDS	A standard protocol that lets e-readers browse and download from your library
OIDC	OpenID Connect — a single sign-on standard for logging in via a third-party provider
Forward Auth	A method where a reverse proxy handles authentication before requests reach BookLore
CBZ / CBR	Comic book archive formats (CBZ = ZIP, CBR = RAR) containing image files
EPUB	The most common e-book file format
Panel Detection	AI feature that identifies individual comic panels on a page
KEPUB	Kobo's enhanced EPUB format
JWT	JSON Web Token — the authentication token used for login sessions
Cron	A scheduling system for running tasks automatically at set times
SMTP	Simple Mail Transfer Protocol — the standard for sending email
Annotation	A highlight, underline, or note you create while reading
Bookmark	A saved position marker in a book
Media Type	A category for your books (e-book, PDF, comic, audiobook, physical, or custom)
Audit Log	A record of actions taken by users in the application
Reverse Proxy	A server that sits between the internet and BookLore, handling security and routing

29. Document Maintenance Log

Important: This guide must be updated whenever features are added, changed, or removed from BookLore. After any fix, feature addition, or removal, review this guide and update the relevant sections. Record changes below to track guide accuracy over time.

Date	Version	Change Description
2026-04-06	1.1.28	Clarified that duplicate review is launched from library menus, removed the book-browser duplicate shortcut, and documented that manual sidecar backup now includes normal digital formats even when books also have non-book attachments
2026-04-06	1.1.27	Documented that manual per-library sidecar backup works in both LOCAL and NETWORK disk modes and clarified that normal EPUB and PDF library backups now resolve book paths correctly instead of reporting zero exported books
2026-04-06	1.1.26	Documented the new manual per-library sidecar backup action in Metadata Persistence, including backups that run even when automatic sidecars are disabled and refresh existing backup sidecars in place
2026-04-06	1.1.25	Documented immediate sidebar filter-mode button selection updates plus the new physical-book directory sidecars that preserve physical placeholders across rebuilds and let sidecar exports include physical books
2026-04-06	1.1.24	Clarified that the duplicate-review dialog now shows stronger active selection states, follows the current theme more closely for its surfaces and comparison cards, and starts the Custom matching preset with all signals cleared
2026-04-06	1.1.23	Documented the saved duplicate-plan snapshot view that exposes queued groups, preferred keeps, and saved scan context before a new scan runs
2026-04-06	1.1.22	Documented that duplicate-resolution plans are now saved to the user account so queued keep choices can be restored on a later review pass
2026-04-06	1.1.21	Documented the new manual duplicate-resolution plan flow, including choosing a preferred keep and exporting a non-destructive follow-up list
2026-04-06	1.1.20	Expanded the duplicate-review documentation to cover the new non-destructive inspection actions, including side-by-side candidate comparison plus quick links to book details and supported readers
2026-04-06	1.1.19	Documented the redesigned duplicate-review workflow, including current-view, current-library, and all-library scan scopes plus the new non-destructive review-only behavior
2026-04-06	1.1.18	Documented that changing sidebar filter modes now clears the active sidebar selections first, and clarified the filter-mode tooltips for the compact AND/OR/NOT/1 controls

2026-04-06	1.1.17	Clarified sidebar filter mode behavior with tooltips and documented that AND mode now narrows same-filter options, such as tags, to combinations that still have matching books
2026-04-06	1.1.16	Documented same-directory physical placeholder duplicate prevention and clarified that deleting a digital book's last readable format now removes accidental empty shells instead of leaving a fileless non-physical entry behind
2026-04-05	1.1.15	Documented that metadata editors can now cancel running bulk metadata fetches from the progress widget without needing full task-manager access
2026-04-05	1.1.14	Documented that cancelling a throttled ComicVine bulk metadata fetch now breaks out of the provider wait immediately instead of waiting for the cooldown to finish
2026-04-05	1.1.13	Clarified throttled ComicVine bulk metadata notifications to show an explicit time-left snapshot alongside the reset ETA
2026-04-05	1.1.12	Documented the reduced-request ComicVine top-match path for bulk metadata scans to lower the chance of hitting hourly API limits mid-batch
2026-04-05	1.1.11	Documented explicit wait-state messaging with ETA for throttled bulk metadata scans while the provider cooldown is in effect
2026-04-05	1.1.10	Documented that throttled bulk metadata requests now retry after the provider cooldown and stay visible as active instead of being mislabeled as stalled
2026-04-05	1.1.9	Documented that bulk metadata scans now wait through temporary provider throttling instead of skipping the remainder of the batch immediately
2026-04-05	1.1.8	Documented the more resilient bulk custom metadata scan behavior when a provider's first candidate fails
2026-04-05	1.1.7	Documented the Physical Books HOME view, library-directory-aware physical book creation, and Physical Media Type filtering
2026-04-05	1.1.6	Documented sidebar-driven thumbnail warming for faster library switching and the new WebP thumbnail delivery path for supported browsers
2026-04-05	1.1.5	Documented per-user Media Type and filter sidebar persistence plus filename-first browsing when selecting directories
2026-04-05	1.1.4	Documented filename fallback for untitled book cards and clarified the metadata editor delete-all action placement near fetch controls

2026-04-05	1.1.3	Documented large-library import feedback, persistent sidebar heading visibility, improved Book Details close behavior, and single/bulk metadata deletion actions
2026-04-04	1.1.2	Documented AI totals in Library Statistics and refreshed guide after book browser and shelf-row UI fixes
2026-04-04	1.1.1	Reviewed guide after README badge repair; no feature workflow changes required in user-facing instructions
2026-04-02	1.1	Added directory explorer documentation to interface, browsing, and filtering sections
2026-03-30	1.0	Initial guide created — covers all BookLore 3.0 features

BookLore 3.0 Familiarization Guide — Maintained as part of the BookLore documentation.
For technical documentation, see the other files in the `docs/` folder. For installation, see `README.md`.